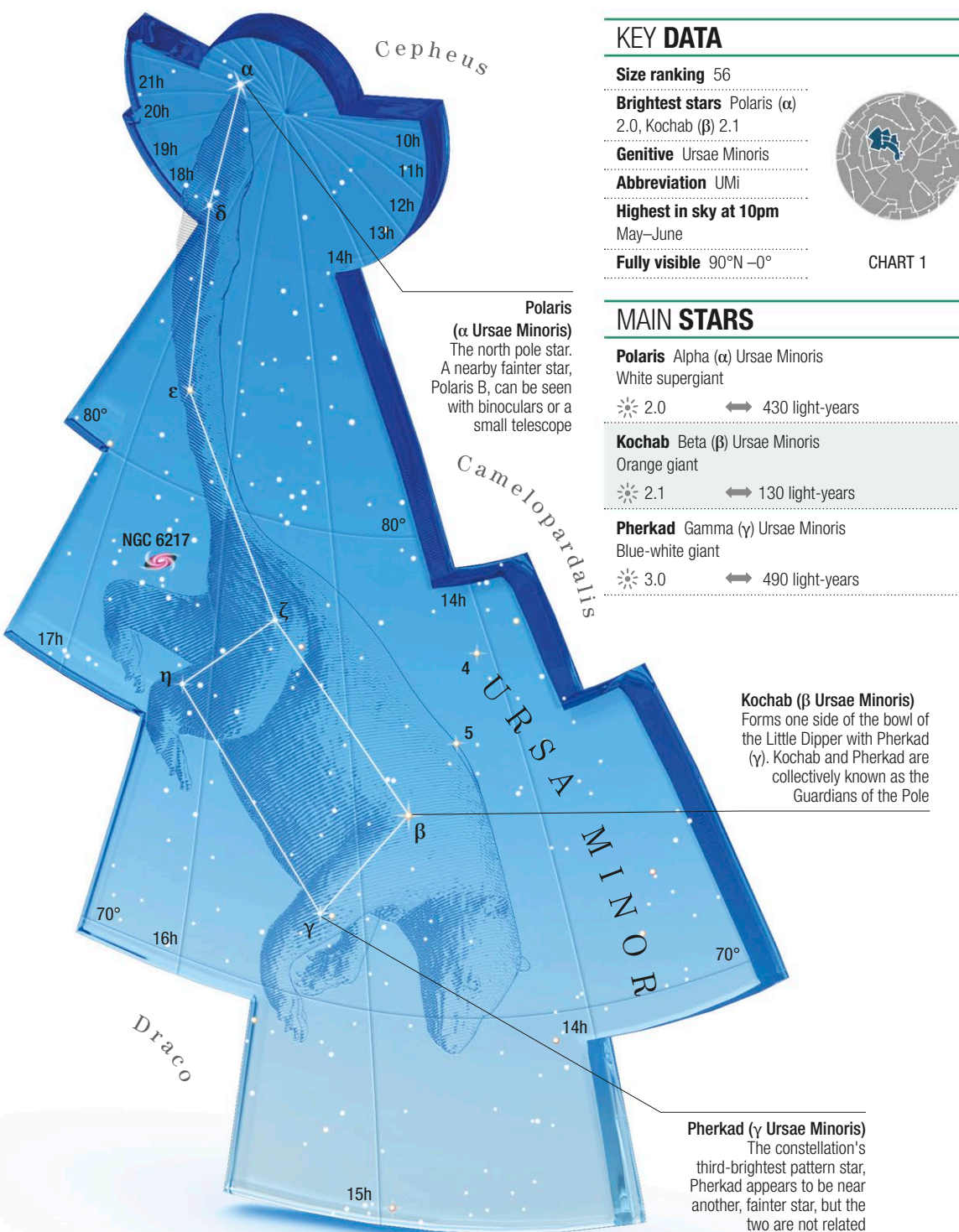


URSA MINOR THE LITTLE BEAR

URSA MINOR CONTAINS THE NORTH CELESTIAL POLE, AND ITS BRIGHTEST STAR, POLARIS, IS THE NORTH POLE STAR. THE CONSTELLATION REPRESENTS A SMALL BEAR, A COMPANION OF URSA MAJOR, THE GREAT BEAR.

Consisting of seven main stars arranged in a saucer shape, Ursa Minor resembles a small version of the Big Dipper, hence its popular name of the Little Dipper. In Greek mythology, it represents a nymph who nursed the god Zeus as an infant. Polaris, its brightest star, lies very near the north celestial pole and is an easy guide to finding north at night.

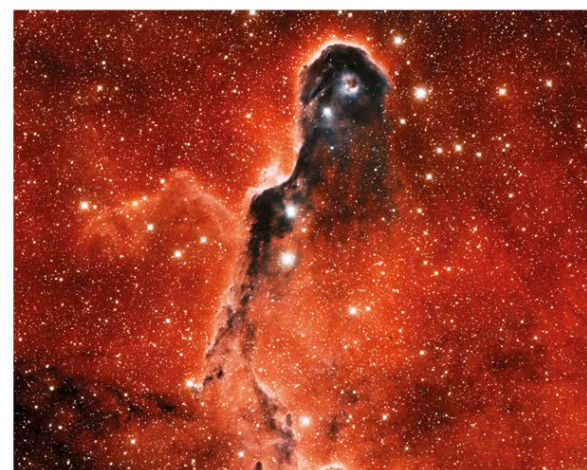


CEPHEUS MYTHICAL KING OF ETHIOPIA

A FAINT NORTHERN CONSTELLATION, CEPHEUS IS SHAPED LIKE A BUILDING WITH A POINTED ROOF. IT REPRESENTS A KING IN GREEK MYTHOLOGY AND CONTAINS THE PROTOTYPE OF THE CEPHEID VARIABLE STARS.

Cepheus was supposedly the King of Ethiopia, a mythical country on the eastern Mediterranean, not the African country we know today. He was the husband of Cassiopeia, who lies next to him in the sky, and the father of Andromeda.

The constellation's most important features are two famous variable stars. Delta Cephei was the first of the pulsating stars known as Cepheid variables to be discovered. In 1784, the English amateur astronomer John Goodricke noted variations in its brightness, which cycles from magnitude 3.5 to 4.4 and back every 5 days 9 hours. It is also a triple star, with one fainter companion visible through a small telescope. Mu Cephei, another variable, is known as the Garnet Star because of its strong red color. A red supergiant, it ranges between magnitudes 3.4 and 5.1 approximately every two years.



△ IC 1396

Situated near the border with Cygnus in the south of Cepheus, IC 1396 is a star cluster surrounded by a large cloud of glowing gas. Seen in silhouette against the bright gas in this image is a dark area called the Elephant's Trunk Nebula, which is a region of gas and dust in which new stars are forming.